

1.1 The Different Versions

Microsoft released Windows XP in two different versions: Windows XP Home Edition and Windows XP Professional Edition. It was readily apparent that the Pro version was the more feature-packed, a point underlined by its higher cost. But soon enough, Microsoft added further versions to the XP stable—the many iterations of Windows XP Media Center Edition, Windows XP Tablet PC Edition, and Windows XP Professional x64 Edition; and then there were spin-offs such as XP Starter Edition and XP Embedded.

With Vista, things are much complex. The most confusing aspect with Windows Vista is deciding which version is right for your needs, and for your budget. It is not clear why Microsoft decided to break up Vista into multiple software units, but the decision has been made: Windows Vista comes in a variety of versions which offer different sets of features in accordance with the market they are targeted at.

Microsoft has created six Vista product editions—targeted at everyone from the entry-level to high-end, premium customers. Plus there are versions specific to national markets such as the N editions for the European Union(EU) and the K editions for South Korea. Add to this 32-bit and x64 variants, and the total tallies up to more than 15 different versions of Vista!

Our task is therefore to clearly list out the various features and quirks of each of these editions, with a view to better understanding just which Vista is the right one to go with.

At least one point becomes very clear—if you want the version that has it all, you need to pick up Windows Vista Ultimate. Vista Ultimate is also the only version that ships with both 32-bit and 64-bit versions inside the same package. For Home Basic, Home Premium and Business Editions, you need to order a 64-bit version separately (you only need to pay for the shipping and handling costs).